



street. “It’s like we can read each other’s minds,” confirms Afsal.

The harmony in training soon worked wonders. His timings dropped rapidly as he asserted his claim as India’s best 800m runner.

In May 2025, he broke Jinson’s national record, nudging the mark to 1:45.61 at a meet in Dubai. Just two months later, he lowered it further, clocking 1:44.93 in Poland.

Besides the twin records, Afsal’s biggest career accolade remains the Asian Games silver he won in 2023.

In the final in Hangzhou, Afsal controlled the race until the end. His strong timing in the heats made him the natural race leader, as the rest of the pack drafted behind him.

“Winning was everyone’s priority. Timing didn’t matter. Everyone followed me, and it was a quick race.”

But in the last 80m, Saudi Arabia’s Essa Kzwani rushed past Afsal, who had to settle for the silver. It is an aberration Afsal intends to correct soon at the Nagoya edition.

Awaiting Afsal, though, is a stiff challenge. As of August 21, Afsal’s season best (1:46.59) places him only

17th on the Asian list. Eight Japanese 800m runners have gone under 1:45 this season, with 19-year-old Ko Ochiai leading the pack with a time of 1:43.45 — the second-fastest by an Asian ever.

Afsal has been religiously tracking his potential opponents and is in no way dazed by any of them.

“I believe I can also do it [go under 1:44] if I get good races. I believe I can push myself to 1:43. When I recorded my PB, it was not an all-out race. We are working really hard to get there,” says Afsal.

On this single-minded pursuit of self-improvement, it was not just Afsal who had to make sacrifices.

Like in a tight 800m race, Afsal had to pull off a photo finish for an important life moment last year — his marriage. This was just days after his second NR, following which he decided to squeeze in another race in Belgium.

“My mother-in-law called me to wish me luck. And then she said, ‘Please make sure you get to the marriage on time,’” says a sheepish Afsal. He ended up reaching only the

Peak moment: Afsal’s biggest achievement remains the Asian Games silver he won in 2023.

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day before his marriage. “In fact, I brought my wedding dress only on the eve of it.”

Ajith, who attended the wedding, allowed his student to rest the day after the marriage. “The very next day, he made me run,” says Afsal.

“My sister had told my wife that you are going to live with a sportsman now and there will be sacrifices.

Now my wife makes fun of me, saying she didn’t expect this many sacrifices,” says Afsal.

All of Afsal’s trade-offs stem from the realisation that he is currently in the final leg of his athletics career, with one big goal left to achieve.

“My dream is to climb to the top of the podium in a major event and hear the national anthem out loud. That is what I want before my retirement,” says Afsal.

Until then, he intends to keep running as he always has.